

The Evolving Chinese Church Around the Globe

Three Windows on One Reality – A Cross-Region Synthesis

CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 · Kuching, Malaysia

Three pastors, three contexts, one conversation. **Bert Han** (Birmingham, UK), **Billy Lo** (Stockholm, Nordic network), and **Enoch Liao** (Boston, USA) each speak from decades inside one place — not a survey, but three seasoned accounts of what they have seen, navigated, and learned. Read side by side, they are windows on the same global reality: a diaspora church continually remade by who arrives next.

▪ The Throughlines — what all three share

- **Migration waves keep rewriting who's in the pews.** No congregation is one community. Each is a stack of waves — a founding restaurant-trade generation, later scholars and students, then newer arrivals — layered under one roof. The people in the room are never who the church was built for.
- **The language-and-generation question is inescapable.** Every context eventually asks: what happens when the next generation's Chinese can't sustain ministry in Chinese? All three are working out the answer in real time — and all three now run English (or English-adjacent) services.
- **Health is defined as formation, not preservation.** None of the three measures a healthy church by size or cultural continuity. Bert asks whether Christ outranks cultural defaults and whether each congregation can evangelize in its own circle; Billy names discipleship that finds your gift and calling — even if it sends you out; Enoch frames a fourfold church (Word, People, Spirit, Mission) that forms whole disciples.
- **The pull between ethnic-identity formation and assimilation/exit.** Each pastor is holding people who could quietly assimilate away — and each insists the church should form people in their heritage rather than ask them to shed it.

▪ Where They Diverge — the sharp edges

- **UK / Bert Han — the flood.** The post-2021 BNO visa sent ~200,000 Hong Kongers to Britain (~20,000 near Birmingham), turning a quietly sunseting Cantonese ministry into five Cantonese services in four years. But it felt less like revival than a corporate acquisition — "merger, not revival" — carrying real grief for what was left behind.
- **Nordic / Billy Lo — language gone universal, and one church across four nations.** The common tongue shifted Cantonese → Mandarin-majority → Swedish → **English** — chosen not for culture but for inclusion; language became universal, not cultural. And the NCCC is literally *one church across four sovereign nations*, now asking whether the 40-year joint scaffold is still needed.
- **USA / Enoch Liao — a century-deep congregation and uniquely American exits.** Boston holds four waves in one body, reaching back to Gold Rush-era roots. Its hardest tension is organizational fragility — great complexity, thin infrastructure — which opened two American exits: **MEMA/MARK churches** (presented as Multi-Ethnic, Mostly Asian; in practice Mostly Asian, Really Korean) and the multiethnic-church movement, compounded by geographic-economic scattering as young people priced out of suburban churches leave and don't return.

▪ One More Axis — generational depth

The contexts differ not just in kind but in *age*. The US has produced 4th- and 5th-generation believers; the UK is largely first-generation BNO arrivals who have never raised children outside a shared-language home; the **Nordic** community sits at roughly two generations. Same global church, three very different clocks.

▪ The Frame

These are not three problems to compare and rank. They are three moments in one unfinished story — a church in the middle of something, more hopeful than anxious, still being remade by who walks in the door next.